



SALTY SCOURGE: The widows of Kharaghoda in their village (left); a family packs its produce sitting beside a mountain of salt



mirror which works as a crude wireless, much like smoke did for the Red Indians. In this desert of mud and salt, there is neither power nor potable water and malnourishment is prevalent because the debt-ridden Agarias can only afford the most basic food. Seven months in an arid and saline area also leads to tuberculosis and cancer. Most suffer from poor eyesight because of lack of vegetables in their diet. Lack of money means they cannot afford to buy rubber boots or gloves that would offer some protection to their ravaged limbs.

The shocking conditions in which they work would have been hidden to the world if it was not for the late Dilip Ranpara, a Gujarati writer, who published a book on their exploitation and sufferings in the early nineties. He described how an Agaria's hands and legs harden and due to their constant work in salt, become nearly acid-proof and therefore take time to burn when his body is put on the funeral pyre. The book, titled *Black Labour, White Blood*, did make some difference thanks to NGOs and social workers but the state government remained oblivious, till recently, allowing the exploitation to carry on unchecked.

Labhubhai Pagi will suffer a loss of at least Rs 10,000 this year following a

An Agaria's hands and legs harden due to constant work in salt and almost become acid-proof. His body takes time to burn when it is put on the funeral pyre.

loss of Rs 2,000 last year. His family will produce around 1,100 tonne of salt this year worth Rs 1.70 lakh which will go into paying back the monthly advances that the trader had given them. He has already spent Rs 1.30 lakh so far, mostly on buying crude oil and digging wells. With four more months to go for the season to end, he will end up spending Rs 1.80 lakh. Says Pagi: "Why can't the government give us subsidy on crude oil or provide us power to operate water pumps? That's the only way we can survive." Crude oil prices have gone up from Rs 3,000 to Rs 7,000 per barrel in three years, but the price paid by traders for inland salt has remained the same. The salt traders, predictably, deny that they exploit the Agarias. Says Laxmikant Parikh, a salt trader at Patdia town: "The Agarias are not victims of exploitation by traders but of the crude oil prices. How can the traders spare margins for the Agarias when their own margins are very low due to huge overheads costs?"

It is thanks to the efforts of an NGO, Gantar, that the state government

has done something to make their lives slightly more bearable. It has sanctioned schools for the Agaria children, promised potable water in tankers at remotely located salt pans, a weekly medical van service besides a limited number of rubber boots. That, however, is clearly too little and too late. Hundreds of young Agarias have already died prematurely, their malnourished bodies unable to withstand the pressure of harsh living conditions.

Now they are faced with another threat. The Little Rann is also home to the wild ass and has been declared a sanctuary by the Gujarat Forest Department. Even though the nearly 4,000 wild asses remain on the periphery of the mud desert, the state forest department wants to throw the Agarias out of the Rann. It has even blocked a government plan to lay a pipeline to the Little Rann to provide potable drinking water to the Agarias. The message is clear: even animals have a higher priority than humans, some of who are already living in sub-human conditions. ■